Rattle Rattle

By Wendy Maclaughlin

INTRODUCTION

(Intro should be said out of character…as narration)
DOCTOR: *Psychology is a very difficult field to be involved in.*
SALLY: *No two people think in exactly the same way*
DOCTOR*: And although the situations of patients may be similar, no two patients react the same.*
SALLY: *But the hardest part…*
DOCTOR*: not becoming a patient yourself.*
BOTH: *"Rattle Rattle"*
SALLY*: By Wendy Maclaughlin*

(DR. WAVERLY enters SALLY's room. She is propped up in bed with a drawing pad in front of her. She draws staring intently into the mirror. He observes her for a moment.)

DOCTOR: How're we doing today?

SALLY: Don't know about you but I'm disjointed.

DOCTOR: *(Writing)* Disjointed?

SALLY: Like everything's turned inside out.

DOCTOR: *(Writes.)* Ummm. Inside out.

SALLY: Why do you repeat what I say?

DOCTOR: I'm trying to understand how you feel.

SALLY: Rattled. Rattled. *(Angry) Rattled!*

DOCTOR: You're in a hospital, Sally.

SALLY: Liar.

DOCTOR: I never lie, Sally. You may not like what I say but I promise you, I don't

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lie. Lying is abhorrent to me.

SALLY: Who are you?

DOCTOR: I'm your doctor. Dr. Waverly.

SALLY: You a real doctor?

DOCTOR: I'm your psychiatrist.

SALLY: I'd rather have a real doctor. What's that thing hanging round your neck?

DOCTOR: This is a stethoscope. To listen to your heart. See?*(Shows it to her.)*

SALLY: Know what I see?

DOCTOR: I'd like you to tell me.

SALLY: I see a psychiatrist trying to act like a real doctor. *(Stares into the mirror and draws.)*

DOCTOR: And what do you see in that mirror, Sally?

SALLY: My face, stupid.

DOCTOR: It's a very nice face.

SALLY: Ugly. All of me is ... ugly.

DOCTOR: Do you remember what happened yesterday?

SALLY: I wet my pants.

DOCTOR: No.

SALLY: In first grade I did. Now why'd I do that? I knew better.

DOCTOR: Do you remember the scissors?

SALLY: What was I doing with scissors?

DOCTOR: Chasing your father.

SALLY: There was this girl. Six years old. She'd hide behind the crack in the door, get her mother's eye, go like this, *(Beckons with her finger)* then peek around the corner, roll her eyes, smack her lips and say... guess what?

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DOCTOR: What?

SALLY: You know.

DOCTOR: No I don't.

SALLY: *(Sing song)* Time to eat.

DOCTOR: *(Probing)* She was six years old?

SALLY: Long as you nursed you weren't supposed to get PG.

DOCTOR: PG?

SALLY: *(Loud) Pregnant!* Mother didn't want to get pregnant again now did she? You're about the dumbest doctor I ever met. How many children do you have?

DOCTOR: One. A boy. A very good boy. Makes straight A's. Going to be a lawyer.

SALLY: Do you love him?

DOCTOR: More than anything in the world.

SALLY: Does he love you?

DOCTOR: He lives with his mother. Yes, I think he does love me. However, I'm aware that his mother would tell you a different story.

SALLY: My mother was in labor twenty-nine hours and she was sick from the first month I was in her tummy. He told me often enough.

DOCTOR: How'd that make you feel?

SALLY: He didn't say she didn't love me. He just said she didn't want me. You can only do so much what with the farm, five children and one on the way. But she was glad to have me after I got here, I'm sure of that.

DOCTOR: You were sure she was glad.

SALLY: *(Strong)* Very sure. I got sick a lot. Asthma, scarlet fever. Mommie let me stay with her on the sleeping porch. Daddy slept ... somewhere else. All I

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could eat was chicken soup. Mother made so much chicken soup it came out her ears. I don't like chicken soup much. Do you? They probably wanted to throw me out with the whole batch. What'd they want with another baby anyway? Especially a *(Exaggerates)* girl. They feed girls to alligators in China.

DOCTOR: That's hard for a girl to understand, isn't it? I'm sorry.

SALLY: If it makes you feel bad I won't tell you any more.

DOCTOR: I guess I'm just a little surprised you aren't sad about what you're saying.

SALLY: Why should I be sad? It's already happened.

DOCTOR: Does anything make you sad?

SALLY: There was this retarded boy in school. He never smiled. The boys were supposed to wear red beanies, the girls green beanies. One day he came to school wearing a green beanie. Everyone laughed. He was so happy. That's about the saddest thing I can think of.

DOCTOR: Does it make you want to cry?

SALLY: I never cry. Even when someone dies. What's there to cry about? They're going home. Every day you pick up the paper and read something about mothers abandoning their babies. Now that's something to cry about. Well, I wasn't abandoned, now was I?

DOCTOR: No, Sally, you weren't abandoned.

SALLY: Mother nursed me so you know she wanted me. I know she wanted the best for me and she knew the best for me was not to be born right then. If I hadn't been born right then, I'd have had a chance to go to someone who really wanted me. See, I'm sure she knew I'd understand. Why would I be

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nursing my doll if I didn't understand.

DOCTOR: Do you still nurse your doll?

SALLY: Do you still play doctor?

DOCTOR: Tell me about your doll.

SALLY: Wendy had long curls and sky blue eyes. We did all my chores together. We loved to gather eggs, reach under their soft white breasts, feel the warm, smooth, oval shells. I took her everywhere, even to the rabbit hutch that time I tried to kill myself.

DOCTOR: Do you want to talk about that?

SALLY: *(Holds out wrists.)* See this? I cut myself with a razor. Not very deep. Then I rubbed rabbit dung into the cut places. Thought I'd get lockjaw and die.

DOCTOR: I'm glad you didn't.

SALLY: Then another time we went out in the snow, took off our clothes, lay down and made snow angels. We were supposed to get pneumonia and die but the only one to die was Wendy. Her funeral was so beautiful. I put daisies over her eyes, a butterfly landed on her nose and all the birds sang ... Wendy. She got her name from Peter Pan. She was Peter Pan's mother. *(Draws.)*

DOCTOR: What're you drawing?

SALLY: My face. I look in the mirror real hard, try to see what I'm thinking. I draw every freckle, every eyelash ... *(Shows him the drawing.)* Does it look like me?

DOCTOR: Yes it does. You're quite an artist. Looks like you're flying.

SALLY: Flying in space. Like Peter Pan. Flying free forever ...forever ... and forever. Sometimes I draw when I get mad. Scared.

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DOCTOR: What kind of things make you mad? Scared?

SALLY: Oh you know... dark nights, shadows on the wall, doorknobs rattling ... men playing cards, beer stink, Mommie crying ... he shouting, "Why'd that kid have to come into our life." I put the pillow over my head. After it got quiet I sneaked downstairs, got my crayons and drew till the sun came in through the window.

DOCTOR: Would you show me those pictures?

SALLY: Too ugly. Burned 'em. *(Challenging)* You wanna draw?

DOCTOR: I can't draw a straight line.

SALLY: Better if you don't. All you do is look in that mirror there. The mirror where you and the others watch me.

DOCTOR: You're a very smart girl, Sally.

SALLY: Girls have to be twice as smart as boys.

DOCTOR: That doesn't seem fair, does it?

SALLY: Lucky it isn't hard. *(Pats chair.)* Sit down. Right here. *(Hands him paper and pencil.)* First thing you gotta do is look in the mirror and get a feeling.

DOCTOR: *(Looks into mirror.)* Don't spend a lot of time looking at myself in the mirror.

SALLY: This isn't about looks. About feelings. Think about something that makes you sad. That isn't much of a feeling. Try getting mad. Come on, Doctor, let your blood boil. Come on, you can do better than that. Yell. Scream. I hate you. I hate you. *(Screams.)* I hate you. *(Works herself into a frenzy and starts hitting him.)* I hate you... I hate you... I *hate you!*

DOCTOR: *(Protects himself with a pillow.)* Go on. Go on.

SALLY: *(Pounding pillow)* Disgusting... stinking ... drunken ... pig. Stay away... get out

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... gooooooooo ...

DOCTOR: Good girl. Hit me harder.

SALLY: *(Piercing scream)* Baaaaaastaaaard! *(Slumps down exhausted.)*

DOCTOR: *(After a pause, a gentle touch)* Sally.

SALLY: *(Jumps like a rabbit.)* Don't you touch me.

DOCTOR: *(Calming)* OK, Sally. It's OK.

SALLY: Stupid. You're a stupid doctor. You haven't drawn one line. Sit there. Take your pencil, put it down on the paper. Now look at yourself and get mad. *Draw!*

DOCTOR: *(Looks into mirror, draws and carefully explains.)* In the art of psychiatry we speak of transference...

SALLY: Grit your teeth, wrinkle your forehead. Good.

DOCTOR: People take their feelings ...

SALLY: Stare.

DOCTOR: ... emotional reactions and patterns ...

SALLY: Don't look at the paper.

DOCTOR: ... they live out with their mother, father ...

SALLY: You're thinking too much.

DOCTOR: ... and project them onto the doctor.

SALLY: Don't blink your eyes.

DOCTOR: Sometimes even the doctor begins to feel...

SALLY: What you see is going down your arm ...

DOCTOR: ... respond like the very people the patient has created.

SALLY: ... right onto the paper.

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DOCTOR: We begin to become ...

SALLY: Your feeling will start to come out ...

DOCTOR: ... what the patient thinks ...

SALLY: ... all over the paper.

DOCTOR: ... rather than what we really are.

SALLY: Let it flow.

DOCTOR: So...

SALLY: Slow and easy.

DOCTOR: Perhaps...

SALLY: *(Low)* Good.

DOCTOR: I've ah ...

SALLY: *(Whispers.)* Magic.

DOCTOR: I... can't believe it.

SALLY: What?

DOCTOR: I... look like my father.

SALLY: He looks sad.

DOCTOR: He was sad.

SALLY: Why?

DOCTOR: He wanted me to be perfect.

SALLY: That can do it.

DOCTOR: When I wasn't he made up stories to make everyone think he was.

SALLY: Did he love you?

DOCTOR: He wanted me to be a surgeon. He thought all psychiatrists were crazy.

"No one has the ability to look into another mind. Nor the right."

SALLY: Do you love him?

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DOCTOR: One day after I got a C in science he sat me down and whispered very precisely, "I don't know how to tell you this and your mother will deny it but I am not your real father."

SALLY: *(Fascinated)* Was it true?

DOCTOR: Another story but I swore to kill myself before I'd end up like him.

SALLY: You ever try?

DOCTOR: Almost everyone has thought of trying.

SALLY: But did you do it?

DOCTOR: Well... I ... ah ...

SALLY: Did you? Did you? *(Pause)* You gonna tell stories like your father?

DOCTOR: Once. Once I tried to kill myself.

SALLY: Do you want to talk about that?

DOCTOR: One rainy night I drove my car into a wall. Expected the engine to come back and smash my chest. It didn't.

SALLY: Isn't that always the way. *(Resumes drawing.)* Funny.

DOCTOR: What's funny is how often we become what we hate.

SALLY: *(Long pause)* I didn't kill him did I?

DOCTOR: No.

SALLY: I misremember some.

DOCTOR: Do you remember what happened yesterday?

SALLY: They were laughing.

DOCTOR: Who was laughing?

SALLY: He and those men.

DOCTOR: What were they laughing at?

SALLY: He was showing them my pictures. Then he called me Mommie's name. Told

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them I was his new wife. It made me sick. I was so mad I ran to my room, got my scissors, crawled under the bed and held my breath. Then later the door knob rattled. Rattled. Then he ... he ... I forget.

DOCTOR: Do you hate your father, Sally?

SALLY: Hate is strong.

DOCTOR: Yes.

SALLY: Mommie says ... he's lonely.

DOCTOR: Are you lonely?

SALLY: Not when I draw. When I draw I go inside to a secret place. A place connected to pretty things.

DOCTOR: What pretty things?

SALLY: Oh you know... birds ... flowers ... Wendy and the farthest star.

DOCTOR: Is that a good place to be?

SALLY: I'm happy there.

DOCTOR: I'm glad, Sally. Very glad. *(Checks watch.)* Well, I have to go. I'll see you tomorrow… I'd like another drawing lesson.

SALLY: OK.

DOCTOR: *(Starts to leave.)* Good-bye, Sally.

SALLY: Doctor Waverly?

DOCTOR: Yes.

SALLY: Next time you draw in the mirror, forget all that stuff about your father.

DOCTOR: In psychiatry we try to remember.

SALLY: Better to forget.

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AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier – Dramatic Interpretation - Female

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